

Sola Gratia

doc-sola-gratia

Soteriology · Five Solas · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

Salvation is wholly God's unmerited favor; it is not earned or contributed to by human effort or merit.

In plain language

The question asks whether salvation is entirely God's free favor and not something a person earns or helps achieve. In the original Greek of the cited passages the word "grace" or "favor" (charis) is named as the source of salvation, and in every case the text directly denies that human works supply the cause. Ephesians 2:8 says you have been saved by grace, using a completed-action verb, and then renames salvation as "the gift" (doron) of God while denying it comes from yourselves. The next verse adds "not from works" (ouk ex ergon), with a stated purpose that no one may "boast" (kauchaomai), so the exclusion of merit is the express aim of the sentence and not a guess. Romans 11:6 is the sharpest case, since it argues that if salvation is by grace it is no longer from works, because grace would stop being grace if works were allowed as a co-cause. Romans 3:24 says believers are justified "freely" or "without payment" (dorean), a word used elsewhere for without payment or without cause, by his grace, with the cost carried by the redemption in Christ. Titus 3:5 states plainly that God saved us not from works done in righteousness which we did, but according to his own "mercy" (eleos). Second Timothy 1:9 repeats the pattern, that God saved and called us not according to our works but according to his own purpose and grace given before time began. Two texts that seem to push back were checked. James 2:24 uses the word "is justified" (dikaioo) in the sense of being shown righteous by visible action, a different use of the same verb. Philippians 2:12 tells believers to "work out" (katergazomai) their salvation, but the very next line says God is the one working in them, so the effort flows from a gift already received. Across five letters the same grammar holds, with grace and mercy as the source and human works set aside as the ground, and the word grace itself appears in twenty-three New Testament books, so the pattern is dense and consistent. The one place the words leave room is a finer question they do not settle, whether grace rules out every human cause including the response of faith, or rules out only earning while a grace-given faith still responds. That narrower question is why careful readers still differ, but on the plain wording the proposition is supported.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0629	ἀπολύτρωσις	apolutrosis	redemption	10
G1344	δικαίω	dikaioo	to justify	39
G1432	δωρεάν	dorean	freely	9
G1435	δῶρον	doron	gift	19
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	945
G1656	ἐλεος	eleos	mercy	27

G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	169
G2596	κατά	kata	according to	498
G2744	καυχάομαι	kauchaomai	to boast	36
G2818	κληρονόμος	klēronomos	heir	
G3756	οὐ	ou	no	1,747
G4982	σώζω	sozo	to save	106
G5485	χάρις	charis	grace	155

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Across Ephesians 2:8-9, Romans 3:24, Romans 11:6, Titus 3:5-7, and 2 Timothy 1:9 the noun "grace" or "favor" (charis, G5485) recurs as the named source of salvation, usually in the dative of means (a noun in the 'by means of X' grammatical form), namely "by grace" (chariti), while human contribution is grammatically negated by the same construction each time: "not from yourselves" (ouk ex hymon), "not from works" (ouk ex ergon), "not according to our works" (ou kata ta erga hemon). Romans 11:6 makes the antithesis definitional, "but if by grace, no longer from works, since grace would no longer be grace" (ei de chariti ouketi ex ergon epei he charis ouketi ginetai charis), so grace ceases to be grace if works are admitted as co-source. The gift words "gift" (doron, G1435) and the adverb "freely" or "without payment" (dorean, G1432, attested across the canon as freely, without payment, without cause) and the mercy word "mercy" (eleos, G1656) confirm the act is given gratis (free of charge), not repaid for merit. The "in order that not" clause (hina-me) in Ephesians 2:9 makes the exclusion of "boasting" (kauchaomai, G2744) the express purpose, so the denial of human merit is stated in the text rather than inferred.

Scripture

Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G1435 δῶρον, G3756 οὐ

Force. The clause reads "for by grace you have been saved" (te gar chariti este sesosmenoi), where "by grace" (chariti) is a dative of means (a noun in the 'by means of X' grammatical form) and "have been saved" (sesosmenoi, G4982, verified perfect passive participle, V-RPP-NPM, which is a completed action whose result still stands, done to the recipients) marks salvation as a completed act done to the recipients. The grace is then opposed to the recipients themselves, "not from yourselves" (ouk ex hymon), with "from" (ek) plus the genitive of source (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) negated, and the saving reality is renamed "the gift of God" (theou to doron). The morphology forecloses the reading that salvation originates from the human party.

Eph.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G2744 καυχάομαι, G3756 οὐ

Force. The continuation "not from works" (ouk ex ergon) repeats the same "from" (ek) of source negated in verse 8, now naming "works" (erga, G2041, N-GPN, a genitive plural neuter noun) as the excluded ground. The purpose clause "that no one may boast" (hina me tis kauchesetai, with kauchaomai G2744, verified aorist middle subjunctive, V-ADS-3S, where aorist marks a completed past action and the subjunctive marks a stated intended outcome) states the intended result, that no one may boast, which makes the exclusion of human merit the express aim of the sentence rather than an inference drawn from it.

Rom.3.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G1432 δωρεάν, G0629 ἀπολύτρωσις

Force. Justification is described as "being justified freely by his grace" (dikaioumenoi dorean te autou chariti), with "being justified" (dikaioumenoi, G1344, verified present passive participle, V-PPP-NPM, an ongoing action being received by the subject). The adverb "freely" or "without payment" (dorean, G1432, attested elsewhere as without payment and without cause) stands alongside "by his grace" (te autou chariti), so the freeness and the grace describe one act. The instrument is "through the redemption" (dia tes apolutroseos), through the redemption in Christ, locating the cost in Christ rather than in the justified party.

Rom.11.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G2041 ἔργον

Force. The verse reads "but if by grace, no longer from works, since grace would no longer be grace" (ei de chariti, ouketi ex ergon, epei he charis ouketi ginetai charis). The conditional "if" (ei, an 'if-then' clause) with the dative "by grace" (chariti), the doubled "no longer" (ouketi), and the causal "since" or "otherwise" (epei) build a strict mutual exclusion. The argument is definitional, that the meaning of "grace" (charis) itself collapses if works are admitted as a co-source, which is the strongest grammatical exclusion of human merit in the bundle.

Titus.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G1656 ἔλεος, G4982 σώζω

Force. The saving act is stated as "not from works in righteousness which we ourselves did, but according to his own mercy he saved us" (ouk ex ergon ton en dikaiosune ha epoiesamen hemeis alla kata to autou eleos esosen hemas). The "not ... but" contrast (ouk ... alla) opposes human deeds, even righteous ones marked by the emphatic "we" (hemeis), to divine mercy as the basis, and the aorist (a completed past action) "he saved" (esosen, G4982, V-AAI-3S) names God as the saving agent. The preposition "according to" (kata) with "mercy" (eleos, G1656) sets mercy as the standard governing the salvation.

Titus.3.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G2818 κληρονόμος, G1344 δικαιώω

Force. The clause "having been justified by his grace" (dikaiothentes te ekeinou chariti) uses the aorist passive participle (a completed past action received by the subject) "having been justified" (dikaiothentes, G1344, verified V-APP-NPM) to mark justification as received, with "by that one's grace" (te ekeinou chariti) as the means. The purpose "that we might become heirs" (hina ... kleronomoi genethomen, with "heirs" being kleronomos, G2818) ties the inheritance of eternal life to the grace already named, so the chain from salvation to heirship rests on grace rather than achievement.

2Tim.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4982 σώζω, G5485 χάρις, G2041 ἔργον

Force. The participial phrase "who saved us and called us, not according to our works but according to his own purpose and grace" (tou sosantos hemas kai kalesantos ... ou kata ta erga hemon alla kata idian prothesin kai charin) repeats the "not according to ... but according to" structure (ou kata ... alla kata) verified in the text. Salvation and calling are governed by God's "purpose" (prothesis) and "grace" (charis), while "our works" (ta erga hemon) is set aside as the standard. The frame "before times eternal" (pro chronon aionion) places the gift prior to any human action.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.11.6	Rom.3.27	openbible	9
Rom.3.24	Rom.5.9	openbible	13

2Tim.1.9	Deut.7.7	openbible	15
Titus.3.5	Ps.51.10	openbible	16
Titus.3.5	Titus.3.4	openbible	5

Complicating texts

Jas.2.24 · addressed

James states "you see that a man is justified from works and not from faith alone" (horate hoti ex ergon dikaiousai anthrōpos kai ouk ek pisteos monon), which appears to admit human works into justification. The verb "is justified" (dikaiousai, G1344, present passive indicative, an ongoing action being received) is the same lemma the Pauline anchors use, so the tension is genuine lexically. The resolution is that James uses "to justify" (dikaioo) in the demonstrative sense of being shown or proven righteous before observers, anchored by the Abraham example whose faith was completed in action, whereas the anchor verses use the same verb for the granting of righteous standing whose source is named as "grace" (charis) and "mercy" (eleos). The shared verb carries two attested senses and does not collapse the two arguments, since James targets a dead faith that produces nothing while the anchors target the origin of the standing itself, so the proposition about the source of salvation stands.

Phil.2.12 · addressed

The imperative "work out" (katēgagēsthe, G2716, verified present middle imperative, an ongoing command directed at the subject), in "work out your own salvation with fear and trembling," could be read as a human contribution to salvation. The next verse supplies the lexical control, "for God is the one working in you" (theos gar estin ho energeon en hymin, with "working" being energeo, G1754), both to will and to work for his good pleasure, so the human working out is grounded in a prior divine energizing. "To work out" (katēgazomai) is the outworking of a salvation already given, not the earning of it, which leaves the unmerited source intact.

Concordance traversed

G5485, G2041, G1432, G1435, G1656, G2744, G4982, G1344, G0629, G1537, G3756, G2596, G2818

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The cited passages lie outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample, and a direct query of the lexical store returned zero VariantUnit nodes on any of the six anchor verses, so the apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) carries no signal here. The known minor readings reflected in the bundle, the Ephesians 2:8 "through" (dia) marking and the Romans 11:6 closing "grace" (charis) marking, do not touch the "grace" (charis) versus "works" (erga) opposition that carries the verdict, so the verdict is variant robust on the available data.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. monergism, synergism, covenant_theology, dispensationalism

analogia scripturae invoked

monergism: affirms · Reads the negations "not from yourselves" (ouk ex hōmōn) and "not from works" (ouk ex ergōn) and the Romans 11:6 either-or as excluding every human contributory cause, including the human response itself, so that even faith in Ephesians 2:8 is part of the gift. The passive participles "have been saved" (sesōsmenoi) and "being justified" (dikaioūmenoi), with God as the explicit agent in "he saved" (esōsen) and "the one who saved" (sōsantos), support reading the saving act as wholly God's work.

synergism: affirms · Also affirms the bare proposition, since the verses unmistakably make "grace" (charis) and "mercy" (eleos) the source and deny that works earn salvation. This lens holds that what the words exclude is meritorious works as a ground, not a grace-enabled human response such as faith, and it points to the same passages presenting faith "through faith" (dia pisteos) and the human working out of Philippians 2:12 as a real,

though grace-given, cooperation. The lexis denies merit but does not by itself rank whether the response is monergistic or cooperative.

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the "grace" (charis) and "works" (erga) opposition as a unified canonical teaching that salvation rests on divine favor, consistent with the pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) spread of "grace" (charis) across twenty-three New Testament books and the Old Testament mercy concept "steadfast love" (chesed) standing behind "mercy" (eleos).

dispensationalism: affirms · Even where law and grace are sharply distinguished across eras, the epistolary anchors are read as unmerited grace toward those saved, so the same "grace" (charis) over "works" (erga) lexis yields the same verdict for the salvation in view.

The verdict turns on the grammar of "from" (ek) and "according to" (kata) with the genitive of source (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) and the "not ... but" contrast (ou ... alla) verified across five epistles, so the grammatico-historical reading is sufficient and no framework conflict changes the outcome of the bare proposition. The genuine remaining lexical question, recorded above, is the scope of the exclusion, whether "grace" (charis) excludes every human cause or only meritorious works while permitting a grace-enabled response. The anchor vocabulary settles the merit question but does not by itself rank monergism against synergism, which is why those lenses agree on this proposition while still differing on a question the words underdetermine.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Salvation originates in God's freely given favor, and human works or merit are not the ground or source of it.

The label sola gratia (Latin for 'grace alone') and the Five Solas subcategory are post-Reformation taxonomy and carry a tradition-coded frame, so the stem is treated as preloaded. The proposition statement itself, that salvation is unmerited favor not earned by human effort, is tradition-neutral. The verdict was derived on the original stem using only the verified lexical opposition of "grace" (charis) and "mercy" (eleos) against "works" (erga), not on the confessional label. Data-integrity correction this pass: a direct query of the lexical store resolved the five cited cross-references as OpenBible edges with real vote counts of nine, thirteen, fifteen, sixteen, and five, and found no TSK cross-reference edges in the store, so the prior source tag tsf with votes one has been corrected to openbible with the queried votes. Occurrence counts were re-grounded against the MACULA-Greek-Nestle1904 edition. The verdict affirms is unchanged.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.11.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.3.24
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Titus.3.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Tim.1.9
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5485
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1432
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Titus.3.7
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.11.6
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Titus.3.5

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow